Playing for Sam

Juniors off to the world championships

Photos courtesy of the USBF



Under-26 USA1 (from left): Bruce Zhu, Michael Hu, Michael Xu, Finn Kolesnik, Harrison Luba and Ethan Wood



Under-26 USA2 (from left): Olivia Schireson, Brent Xiao, Cornelius Duffie, Stella Wan, Richard Jeng and Jacob Freeman



The top three pairs in the Under-26 Women's competition (from left): Nicole Qiang, Helen Chow, Cecilia Ehrlichman, Katie Hwang, Sharon Chu and Ella Su

The 2024 Sam Amer Junior U.S. Bridge Championships were held in late December in Atlanta. These trials select the teams who will represent the U.S. at the 2025 World Youth Bridge Teams Championships. The competition is sponsored by the United States Bridge Federation.

The trials were named after Sam Amer, who was a bridge professional in New York City and a beloved member of the bridge community. He was a former member of the USBF Junior program and represented the U.S. in the 2018 WYBTC. He was known for his incredible kindness towards others and his infectious passion for the game. Sam died in 2023 of an accidental fentanyl overdose.

"Through collaboration with Sam's family, we paid homage to Sam by celebrating ways to 'be like Sam' and promoted fentanyl awareness," said Amber Lin, who coordinates the Online Junior Training Program.

Almost all the 115 participants attended the two-day training camp prior to the trials, organized by Lin and Kevin Rosenberg and sponsored by the ACBL Educational Foundation, including two young players from the Mexican Bridge Federation and their mentor/coach, Patricia Herrera. Several mentors helped during the training, including some of the parents who were there with their children. Presenters during the camp, in addition to Amber and Kevin, included Debbie Rosenberg, Patty Tucker, Kevin Collins, Adam Kaplan and Anant Rathi.

The camp included lessons, practice team matches, and fun activities like "Crazy Bridge," where the rules were slightly modified (e.g. one revoke per hand allowed).

The Under-21 and -26 teams played round robins and then knockouts. "We did something new and different to select the two U16 teams and the two U26 Women's teams," said Joe Stokes, the USBF Junior Coordinator. "Although the participants have been part of the USBF online training program organized by Alex Kolesnik and Lin, with help from dozens of online mentors, they did not necessarily know each other 'in real life.' It seemed unrealistic to expect them to form teams for the competition.

"In each group, the top three pairs at the end of the competition were guaranteed a spot on one of the two teams. The other three pairs were chosen via a review of the hands they bid and played, using anonymized data."

The other three pairs are (in no particular order) U26W: Ava Donnellan, Kyra Helmbold, Jasmine Bakhshi, Katie Sullivan, Caroline Zhao and Jessie Cai.

U16: Kyo Chen, Zinnia Meyer, Alex Shih, Jayson Lee, Lee Blocher and Alex Xu.

Here's a deal written up by Kayden Ge, who is on the U21 USA2 team.

All that for a push

By Kayden Ge

In the fifth round of the U21 round robin, my team faced Team Silverstein, the two squads that eventually became USA2 and USA1, respectively.

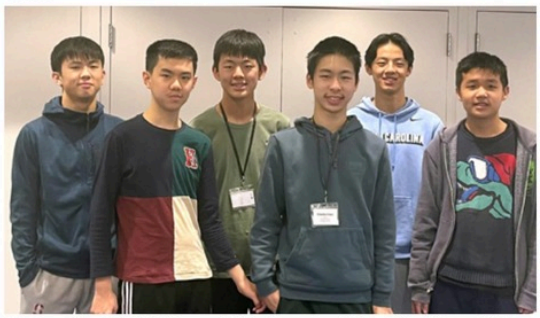
On the sixth board of the match, I, sitting South, picked up:

♠K 9 ♥J 8 6 4 ♦K 10 8 5 4 3 ♣5.

The auction started with West as dealer, both vulnerable:



Under-21 USA1 (from left): Jack Boge, Ethan Derman, Avery Silverstein, Daniel Balof, Sam Pahk and Michael Haas



Under-21 USA2 (from left): Kayden Ge, Eric Xiao, Brian Zhang, Charlie Chen, Brandon Ge and Arthur Gong



The top three pairs and their mentors in the Under-16 competition (from left): Adam Hemmer, Kate Lee, Amber Lin, Andrew Chen, Jeff Xiao, Kevin Rosenberg, Kevin Wei and Arjun Chaunal

West	*North*	*East*	*Me*
1♣(1)	1NT	2♣(2)	2♠(3)
Dbl	Pass(4)	Pass	3♦
Pass	4♦	Pass	5♦
All Pass			

(1) 2+, could have longer diamonds
(2) Both majors (at least 5/4)
(3) Range ask or diamonds
(4) Undiscussed

When I bid 2♠, my original plan was to transfer to diamonds if partner rebid 2NT, showing a minimum. If he bid 3♦ showing a maximum, I would bid 3NT. But West doubled and partner passed, which we had never discussed. I interpreted it as lacking a spade stopper, so I decided 3NT would be too dangerous and bid 3♦ myself as a signoff, protecting my spade holding by right-siding the contract. When partner then raised to 4♦, I felt obligated to bid 5♦.

West led the ♣K, and I was met with:

Dlr:West
Vul: Both

♠ A 7 5
♥ A 3
♦ A 7 6
♣ Q J 10 9 8

♠ K 9
♥ J 8 6 4
♦ K 10 8 5 4 3
♣ 5

Clearly, my interpretation of his pass was wrong, as he did have a spade stopper, making 3NT the far superior contract.

East followed to the first club trick, and West switched to the ♥2, which I won with the ace. Because West would have led high from doubleton, I now knew he had exactly three hearts because East must have four for his 2♣ bid. Knowing this, I played another heart from dummy, hoping to ruff my last two hearts in dummy if the defense returned anything other than a trump. (This line relies on the fact that West must ruff with a diamond honor on the fourth heart and my ability to pick up the trump suit afterwards.)

East hopped up with the ♥K and returned a trump, so my original line of ruffing two hearts can still work only if West has a singleton diamond honor, in which case I can play for a trump coup by ruffing clubs to shorten my trump. However, I found it unlikely that East would return a trump from Q–9–x or J–9–x, so I ruled that out.

I turned to the possibility of a squeeze. I had three threat cards: the ♣Q and the third spade in dummy, and the ♥J in my hand. For the squeeze to work, I would have to ruff a third heart in dummy in order to isolate East's ♥Q guard. The lead and the opening bid also marked West with the ♣A. This meant after I ran off all my winners, neither defender could hold enough spades in addition to their other guard. So, I played diamonds to be 2–2, and when they broke, I ruffed a heart in dummy, crossed back by ruffing a club, and ran off my trumps, cashing the ♠K before the last one to make the position crystal clear. Sure enough, this was the three-card ending I had envisioned:

	♠ A 7 ♥ — ♦ — ♣ Q	
♠ Q 8 ♥ — ♦ — ♣ A	N W E S	♠ J 10 ♥ K ♦ — ♣ —
	♠ 9 ♥ J ♦ 3 ♣ —	

When I led the ♦3, West had to hold on to his ♣A, so he was forced to pitch a spade. When I discarded the ♣Q, East was helpless. Pitching a spade would set up the third spade in dummy, and pitching the ♥K would set up my ♥J.

At the other table, North played a stress-free 3NT, as with diamonds breaking, he simply cashed nine top tricks. All that for a push board.

(Note that if West tries a spade at trick two to break up the squeeze, South can simply draw trumps and concede a club trick.)

"This was a terrific event, which we expanded to include the training camp with funding from the ACBL Educational Foundation," said Stokes. ■